Florentius Kurzer, O.F.M. — Die St. Franziskus-Gemeinde Humphrey, Nebraska (1908)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This presentation is dedicated to the Rev. Florentius Kurzer, O.F.M., a blacksmith's son driven out of Germany by the Kulturkampf while still a teenage friar, who crossed the Atlantic and became pastor of a prairie parish in Nebraska. There, in German, he wrote down the first twenty-five years of that parish himself, as a gift for its silver jubilee. His booklet, covering 1883 to 1908, is a parish history and also a membership directory, holding the names of a whole German-Catholic town world that has since vanished. The dedication follows the folder's own: to the German-Catholic parishes of the high plains.

The story

Florentius Kurzer was born John Kurzer on 18 December 1857, the son of Joseph Kurzer, a blacksmith, and Hedwig, née Koenig. He was invested in the Franciscan Order at Warendorf on 13 October 1874. Before he could complete his novitiate, the Kulturkampf forced him to leave Germany with many confreres. He arrived in New York on 30 June 1875, made his simple profession at Teutopolis, Illinois, on 16 October 1875, and his solemn vows on

28 October 1878. He was ordained at St. Louis on 28 May 1882.

His early work took him to missions in Illinois, to Chanhassen, Minnesota, from 1887 to 1894, and then to St. Bernard, Nebraska, as superior and pastor for five years. By the chapter of 28 December 1898 he was transferred to Humphrey, serving as pastor from January 1899 to August 1909. Humphrey, plainly, is the town in Platte County, Nebraska, not a person. In that first pastorate he cancelled the parish debt, built a larger modern school, and celebrated his silver sacerdotal jubilee in 1907. After about a year and a half at Quincy, Illinois, he was recalled to Humphrey, serving again from 5 January 1911 to July 1918 and building the new monastery and residence in 1912. In 1919 he was sent again to Chaska, Minnesota, for Chanhassen, and in 1922 he travelled to his old home in Europe, unseen since 1875.

The work and what survives

The work is *Die St. Franziskus-Gemeinde Humphrey, Nebraska, in ihrem Entstehen und Wachsen von 1883–1908*, a commemorative gift for the silver jubilee of St. Francis Parish. It was printed by Willwerscheid & Raith at Saint Paul in 1908; the Internet Archive holds it as `stfranziskusgeme00kurz`. In his preface, signed simply as pastor, Kurzer says the booklet was written to put the members in remembrance of the twenty-five years since the parish's founding on 10 July 1883, and to show other parishes what unity between members and pastor can achieve.

Kurzer treats the town, the founding and history of the parish, the friary and its pastors, the school, the societies, the parishes served from Humphrey, the religious who came from the parish, statistics, services and devotions, and remarks on the sacraments. He then gives an alphabetical list of the members and closes with the advertisements of 1908. The folder's editor's note counts thirteen societies and 203 households. Humphrey arose in 1879 with a Union Pacific branch line and counted somewhat over 1,000 inhabitants by 1908, about half Catholic. The great brick church succeeded the frame church in 1894. The German original survives, in a modern Forgotten Books Classic Reprint.

Its English fortunes

The folder's finding stands at its full strength: **no English rendering of this booklet was found after research**. Only the German original and its German facsimile reprint were found, not any English edition. No stronger claim is made, because no union-catalogue search was run in this pass.

What completing it would take

No new translation is needed. The folder already holds a complete draft English translation, directory and 1908 advertisements included, made from page images of the Fraktur original because the archive's machine-read text is unusable. Completing the edition means verification: every reading flagged as uncertain must be collated against the Fraktur page images and resolved, surnames above all, since the directory is the booklet's genealogical core, with the 1983 centenary history and *The Franciscans in Nebraska* as name cross-checks. The portrait plates, carried by captions only, await a decision on reproduction. The statistics table must be checked as preserved, its original arithmetic left as printed and any printer's errors annotated rather than corrected.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/kurzer-st-franziskus-humphrey/kurzer-st-franziskus-humphrey.txt`
- *The Franciscans in Nebraska*, NEGenWeb: https://usgennet.org/usa/ne/topic/religion/catholic/Franciscans/pages/pt2/fine0019c.htm and https://usgennet.org/usa/ne/topic/religion/catholic/Franciscans/pages/pt2/fine0019e.htm
- USGenWeb Archives, index to *A Century Together 1883–1983*: http://files.usgwarchives.net/ne/platte/publication/stfrancis/stfran.txt
- Forgotten Books Classic Reprint listing: https://www.thegreatbritishbookshop.co.uk/products/die-st-franziskus-gemeinde-humphrey-nebraska-in-ihrem-entstehen-und-wachsen-von-1883-1908-eine-festgabe-zur-erinnerung-an-ihr-sibernes-jubilaum-classic-reprint
- Internet Archive: `stfranziskusgeme00kurz`